Its owner, Shaul Elovitch, is thought to be close to Netanyahu. “And who’s handling the negotiations? The communications minister,” said one Walla journalist. “The editor in chief has asked to personally review any stories dealing with Netanyahu.”

Bottles and Bibitours

It was Netanyahu’s third trip to Moscow in nine months, a visit meant to highlight the deepening ties with Israel’s newest neighbor in the Middle East. He reached out to Vladimir Putin after the latter sent troops to prop up the Assad regime in Syria, and the two quickly became close. “We place great importance on our relationship with Israel,” said Putin, who courted the Israeli prime minister with a surprise tour of the Kremlin and tickets to the Bolshoi.

Yet the first question at their 7 June press conference, from a reporter with Israel’s state-run Channel 1, was about an explosive scandal involving a French financier who has been linked to kidnapping and murder. It was the latest in months of salacious stories about Netanyahu and his wife Sara, and the prime minister could barely contain his frustration. “They trample the image of my wife and turn her into human dust,” he said, accusing the media of “systemic persecution”.

The interpreter at the Kremlin declined to translate the lengthy answer into Russian, saying it was about domestic issues. “But why?” Putin asked with a chuckle. “It’s interesting to us, too.”

If there is one man in Israeli politics who can bring down Benjamin Netanyahu, it is Benjamin Netanyahu. He has featured in a truly impressive list of corruption scandals during his eight-plus years in office. Many of them are small-time swindles—a politician taking advantage of his position to live the high life, or just to line his pockets a bit (like the absurd “Bottlegate” scandal, in which his wife pocketed the eight-cent refunds from returning empty wine bottles that were purchased by the state). But several are not. His personal lawyer, David Shimron, has been accused of a conflict of interest in Israel’s $1.3 billion purchase of three submarines from Germany. Shimron also works with ThyssenKrupp, the German conglomerate that manufactures the subs. The deal was approved in 2016 after an unusually short period of discussion; Moshe Ya’alon, who was the